

Do You DIY?

Do-it-yourself (DIY) is the ultimate experience for geeks and techies! It challenges their capabilities and helps expand their horizons. While DIY has been around in many fields since time immemorial, we see it gaining popularity with the advent of online communities and marketplaces. The new-age DIY culture makes it possible for tinkerers to realise any idea, with components and know-how sourced from around the world.

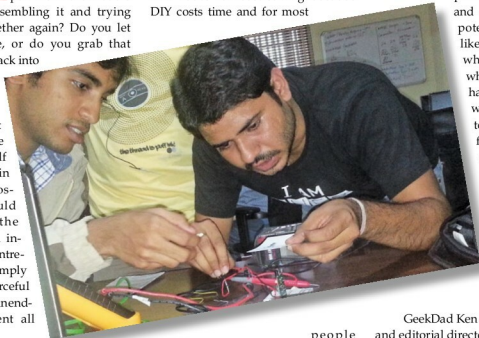
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Have you ever seen little children, who have just learnt to sit up, grabbing a ball-point pen from their dad's pocket, disassembling it and trying to put it together again? Do you let them meddle, or do you grab that pen, stash it back into your pocket and walk off? Well, this is the earliest sign of the do-it-yourself (DIY) craze in a person. Fostering it could transform the child into an innovator, an entrepreneur or simply a very resourceful person with unending excitement all lifelong!

While DIY exists in almost everything from music and crafts to plumbing and carpentry, it is especially interesting, developmental and community-oriented in technical fields like electronics and robotics. Here we attempt to figure out what makes electronics DIY so interesting and purposeful, how people go about it (is there a standard 'route'), what they need and where they get the stuff, what boards or components they prefer, and how vibrant the community is in India.

Why DIY?

Jayakrishnan T., CEO of Asimov Robotics, is a robotics DIYer who later built a company around his passion. He feels that very few people go the DIY route for cost-saving because DIY costs time and for most



people that is more valuable than money. Most people do it because they are passionate about it. A lot of people walk down the DIY path to familiarise themselves with something they have always been apprehensive of doing, or they do it to quickly get something that is not readily available. Many a times, a DIY project might revolve around modifying or upgrading an existing solution to satisfy a specific need or to fix a problem associated with the solution.

This resonates with the thoughts

of Nagasai Panchakarla, entrepreneur and co-organiser of a Bangalore-based Internet of Things DIY group (IoT-BLR). Nagasai feels that "DIY is all about creation. In order to create something, DIYers will come across a lot of questions for themselves and explore their own potential... questions like what do I know, what do I not know, what resources do I have, who will work with me and how to get things done from constrained resources. This will bring in the entrepreneurial mindset of converting imagination into a product that one loves."

Ken Denmead, popularly known as

GeekDad Ken in the cyber-world, and editorial director of Maker Media, feels that the biggest positive aspect of DIY projects is empowerment. People should be connected to the things they own and use, and helping people feel empowered to make things themselves helps them achieve those connections," he explains.

Nihal Kashinath, IoT enthusiast and founder of IoTBLR, feels that DIY results in democratisation of technology and design, which is a wonderful thing. Anyone can create anything, and no one needs to be satisfied with the products or specifications put forth